

PROJECT FEMME

State of Play & Strategic Briefing

Female-First Oral Nicotine Brand Innovation

Prepared For:	FRE Innovation Team, Turning Point Brands
Date:	February 20, 2026
Classification:	Confidential — Internal Use Only
Status:	Active — Approaching Q2 2026 DTC Launch Window

BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT: Project Femme is a category creation play — not a product launch. TPB is positioned to launch the first purpose-built female oral nicotine brand in the U.S. market, targeting a \$600M+ annual revenue opportunity by exploiting the intersection of consumer white space, PMTA regulatory moats, and a channel strategy that uses premium retail to bust stigma. Three lead concepts (NOON, QUIET SOCIETY, VIA) are advancing toward Q2 2026 DTC launch.

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1. The Thesis: Why This, Why Now

The U.S. nicotine oral pouch market is on a trajectory from an estimated **\$2B to \$5B over five years**, driven by discretion, perceived health benefits over combustible alternatives, and expanding consumer segments (athletes, productivity users, wellness-adjacent consumers). Yet every entrenched player — Zyn (Philip Morris), On! (Altria), Velo (BAT) — speaks exclusively to men.

Female consumers represent an estimated **~20% of the nicotine pouch market** today and are increasing participation. The original innovation brief sized the addressable opportunity at **\$600M in annual revenue** — achievable by capturing 2% of total market share from Zyn/On! incumbents and owning 10% of currently available market share.

TPB's Structural Advantages for This Play:

- FDA-approved product vehicles (FRE pouches + Cotton Mouth infused cotton) providing a regulatory moat
- Existing manufacturing, distribution, and sales infrastructure to support rapid GTM execution
- The PMTA barrier functioning as an artificial moat — new entrants face \$1M+ and 12+ months to secure approval, creating first-mover advantage for brands that can leverage existing approvals
- Lucy white-label partnership expanding strength/format options without new FDA submissions

Target Audience Hypothesis (Two Segments):

- **Segment 1 — Underserved Switchers:** Existing female oral nicotine users (hypothesized lower-strength preference) who don't feel served by current offerings and will switch to a brand that speaks to them.
- **Segment 2 — Category-Curious Recruits:** Female consumers who are nicotine-adjacent (cigarettes, vape, cannabis spliffs) but see nothing "for me" in the oral nicotine category and may trial a new brand.

2. The Arc: How We Got Here

TRIPTK was engaged as the innovation partner in September 2025. The original scope was a five-phase process spanning approximately 20 weeks. Here is the phase-by-phase narrative of how the project evolved:

Phase 0: Agency Selection & Briefing (September–October 2025)

The innovation brief was issued to TRIPTK, a multidisciplinary agency specializing in brand strategy and cultural research. The partnership requirement was explicit: stretch TPB thinking with innovative and novel ideas around positioning, branding, and GTM, while paying heed to business conventions. The innovation should leverage existing TPB products — either or both FRE pouches or Cotton Mouth infused cotton.

The five-phase scope was agreed: Opportunity Exploration (~3 weeks) → Innovation Platform (~2 weeks) → Concept Creation (~3 weeks) → Testing & Validation (~6 weeks) → Strategy & Design (~6 weeks).

Phase 1: Foundational Research & Hypotheses (October–November 2025)

This phase delivered the critical consumer insights that reframed the entire project. Activities included:

- **Stakeholder Interviews:** Internal interviews with key TPB personnel to surface early hypotheses and gather organizational knowledge (documented in TRIPTK_Interviewee_List and FRE_Stakeholder_Interview_Probes).
- **Qualitative Consumer Research:** Immersive interviews (~n30) with female nicotine consumers via the Vurvy platform, probing motivations, barriers, sensory preferences, social context, and gender/image perceptions.
- **Landscape & Cultural Analysis:** Competitive scan, cultural code analysis, and best-in-class audit of analogous category shifts (male-dominated to female-inclusive).
- **Market Sizing:** Independent market sizing exercise estimating the female nicotine pouch opportunity in the U.S. (documented in Female_Nicotine_Pouch_US_Market_Sizing).
- **Hypothesis Framework:** Findings codified into testable propositions (TRIPTK_Hypotheses_Framework), including H5 (controlled relief), H10 (stigma), H11 (aesthetics), H12 (address shame directly), and H18 (accessories).

KEY DISCOVERY: Women aren't rejecting oral nicotine for cosmetic reasons — they report significantly higher rates of stomach upset, nicotine overwhelm, and gum irritation from existing products. The product experience itself is the primary barrier, compounded by social stigma from male-coded c-store distribution.

Phase 2: Innovation Platform (November 2025)

Consumer insights translated into strategic territories and design principles. The "Ritual Reset" hypothesis emerged as a unifying platform — the insight that the product moment isn't about getting a nicotine hit; it's about a micro-ritual of recalibration. Female consumers framed their desired experience around calm, composure, and settling (controlled relief) rather than activation or intensity.

Phase 3: Concept Creation (November–December 2025)

TRIPTK delivered **eight conceptual territories** organized around the Ritual Reset platform: NOON, QUIET SOCIETY, VIA, ATLAS, STILLPOINT, JUST, SOLSTICE, and DAYTURN. Each concept was developed with brand narrative, RTBs (reasons to believe), visual identity, packaging concepts, and activation scenarios.

Two rounds of internal evaluation followed (V1 and V2), applying three critical lenses: (1) regulatory feasibility per General Counsel guidance, (2) alignment with validated consumer hypotheses, and (3) commercial viability for 2026 market entry. V2 introduced a fourth lens — channel strategy fit — which fundamentally changed the

evaluation outcome for several concepts.

3. Consumer Insight Stack

The following insights emerged from Phase 1 research and form the strategic foundation for all concept development. They are codified in the Hypotheses Framework and validated through consumer qualitative research.

H5: Controlled Relief Over Maximum Buzz

Female consumers consistently prefer calm, composure, and settling over activation or intensity. This directly contradicts the "stronger is better" positioning of every incumbent brand. The DAYTURN concept was killed specifically because its "upbeat activation" messaging violated this insight.

H10: Stigma is Structural, Not Cosmetic

Social stigma around female oral nicotine use is deep and multifaceted. It stems not just from packaging aesthetics but from the retail environment (c-store backbar), the association with male tobacco culture ("dip-switchers"), and the nicotine/cancer conflation that even 80% of physicians get wrong. Pink packaging does not solve a structural problem.

H11: Aesthetics as Permission Structure

Premium, elevated design doesn't just make the product "pretty" — it functions as a permission structure that allows women to carry and use the product without shame. The accessory/compact becomes as important as the pouch itself.

H12: Address Shame Directly

Brands that acknowledge stigma rather than ignoring it create stronger emotional bonds. QUIET SOCIETY's "stigma-to-sophistication" reframe scored highest on this dimension by turning nicotine use into a mark of discernment rather than a habit to hide.

H18: Accessories as Differentiation

Since regulatory constraints prevent product formulation changes, accessories (compacts, cases, refillable formats) become the primary vehicle for physical differentiation. These items are unregulated and can be sold in channels where nicotine itself cannot (e.g., the "Hardware Strategy" for Sephora).

Product Experience Barriers (Qualitative)

Female consumers report significantly higher rates of stomach upset, nicotine overwhelm, and gum irritation compared to male users. This suggests that existing products were not designed with female physiology and preferences in mind — lower strengths (4mg entry point via Lucy) and smoother mouthfeel are critical.

4. Concept Evaluation Summary

Eight concepts were evaluated across two rounds. The table below reflects the final (V2) assessment, which incorporated the channel strategy lens and the Lucy partnership's impact on regulatory feasibility.

Concept	H-Fit	Reg.	Channel	Stigma	Recommendation
QUIET SOCIETY	●●●	●●●	★★★	●●●	ADVANCE - Prestige Play
NOON	●●●	●●●	●●●	●●■	ADVANCE - Anchor
VIA	●●●	●●●*	●●●	●●●	ADVANCE - System Play
STILLPOINT	●●●	●●●	●●●	●●●	ADVANCE - Dev Visual
ATLAS	●●●	●●●	●●■	●●■	ADVANCE - Mass Expansion
JUST	●●●	●●■	●●●	●●■	HOLD - Legal Review
SOLSTICE	●●■	●●●	●●■	●●■	HOLD - Backup
DAYTURN	●■■	●●●	●●■	●■■	KILL - Wrong Strategy

* VIA regulatory rating upgraded in V2 based on Lucy partnership providing 4mg/8mg/12mg strength ladder without new FDA submissions.

The Three Lead Concepts

NOON (Anchor / Volume Driver)

Positioning: The midday reset. Anchored to a universally understood moment when mental and emotional load peaks. Prioritizes smoothness, comfort, and a settling mouthfeel. Clear, intuitive need-state that maps naturally to daily routine.

Why It Wins: Highest emotional resonance in qualitative testing. Clean regulatory path. "Pause, recalibrate, continue" is immediately comprehensible. Best-fit channels: Sephora, Ulta, DTC.

QUIET SOCIETY (Prestige Halo)

Positioning: Soft-luxury composure with understated social confidence. Built for people who prefer composure over intensity and subtle cues over big statements. "Private club" metaphor enables premium design language.

Why It Wins: Highest differentiation ceiling of all eight concepts. "Stigma-to-sophistication" angle is unique in category. Enables invitation-only launch, membership model, and luxury accessory collaborations. Best-fit

channels: Boutiques, luxury department stores, members-only DTC.

VIA (System / Retention Engine)

Positioning: Day-part system (AM/MID/PM) with distinct strength and flavor profiles for different occasions. Originally killed in V1 on regulatory grounds, but the Lucy partnership providing 4mg/8mg/12mg strengths removed the blocker.

Why It Wins: Strongest retention mechanics through subscription model. Day-part system creates habitual multi-occasion usage. Best-fit channel: Subscription DTC. Risk: Supply chain complexity; recommended for Phase 2 after anchor brand is established.

5. The Channel Strategy Reframe

CENTRAL INSIGHT: The c-store channel itself IS the stigma. No amount of "female-friendly" packaging overcomes the context of buying nicotine next to the gas pump. Channel does perception work that messaging alone cannot accomplish — instantly, implicitly, and without regulatory constraint.

The V2 concept evaluation introduced channel fit as a critical fourth evaluation dimension. The analysis, supported by McKinsey, BCG, and Bain research on distribution strategy and brand perception, demonstrates that for stigmatized categories, the retail environment is the **first brand touchpoint** — encountered before packaging, messaging, or product experience.

Channel	Signal to Consumer	Stigma Impact
C-Store Backbar	<i>"Habit for truckers and dip-switchers"</i>	REINFORCES stigma
Sephora / Ulta	<i>"Part of my self-care routine"</i>	NEUTRALIZES stigma
Premium Boutique	<i>"Curated accessory for the curated life"</i>	INVERTS stigma
DTC / Subscription	<i>"Private, premium, on my terms"</i>	SIDESTEPS stigma

The Portfolio-Tier Channel Architecture

Tier	Concept	Channel	Role
Prestige	QUIET SOCIETY	Boutiques, luxury dept stores	Halo brand
Core	NOON (or STILLPOINT)	Sephora, Ulta, DTC	Volume driver
System	VIA (AM/MID/PM)	Subscription DTC	Retention engine
Mass	ATLAS	GNC, broad wellness (post-equity)	Scale play

The "Hardware Strategy" (Regulatory Loophole):

You cannot sell nicotine in Sephora, but you can sell the container. Sell the QUIET SOCIETY Compact (empty) as a \$45 fashion accessory. It contains a QR code for the "Refill" via DTC. This gets brand presence into the forbidden channel without regulatory impossibility — and creates a recurring revenue flywheel.

6. Regulatory Constraints & Product Portfolio

General Counsel guidance draws a hard line on what is executable for a 2026 MVP. The principle of "regulatory judo" applies: differentiate through packaging, accessories, channel, and positioning — not product formulation.

MVP-SAFE (What We CAN Change)	TRIGGERS NEW FDA PATH (What We CAN'T)
✓ Pack graphics, finish, coatings	✗ Pouch material changes
✓ Pack shape (same interior cavity)	✗ Interior cavity volume changes
✓ Existing approved flavors	✗ New nicotine strengths (\$1M+, 12+ mo)
✓ Existing approved strengths	✗ Two actives in one product
✓ Accessories (unregulated)	✗ Brand styling overlapping non-nicotine
✓ Lucy partnership formats (Breakers, Gum)	

Available Product Portfolio

Source	Format	Strengths	Flavors
FRE (existing PMTA)	Pouch	6mg, 12mg	Current portfolio
Lucy Partnership	Pouch	4mg, 8mg, 12mg	Coffee, Cinnamon, Mango
Lucy Partnership	Breakers (capsule)	TBD	TBD
Lucy Partnership	Gum	TBD	Coffee, Cinnamon, Mango
Cotton Mouth	Infused cotton	Per approval	Per approval

KEY UNLOCK: The Lucy partnership provides the 4mg/8mg/12mg strength ladder that makes VIA's day-part system feasible without new PMTA submissions. This single partnership changed the feasibility assessment on VIA from "DO NOT ADVANCE" (V1) to "ADVANCE" (V2).

7. Where We Stand Now (February 2026)

The project has shifted from agency-led strategy development to internally controlled execution. The strategic foundation is locked; the work ahead is commercialization.

■ Three Lead Concepts In Play

NOON (anchor/volume driver), QUIET SOCIETY (prestige halo), and VIA (system/retention) are advancing. ATLAS is held for post-equity mass expansion. STILLPOINT remains a developmental backup to test against NOON.

■ Agency Relationship Recalibrated

TRIPTK's scope has been reduced from full-service strategy to visual execution and prototype development. The strategic foundation is now controlled internally by the FRE Innovation Team.

■ DTC Launch Targeting Q2 2026

Direct-to-consumer is the fastest path to market and sidesteps the complexity of premium retail buyer conversations. DTC also enables subscription mechanics critical for VIA's retention model.

■ Consumer Testing Protocol Pending

Testing must be designed to show concepts in context — Sephora environment mockups, not white-room concept boards. This is critical for validating the channel-as-brand-signal thesis.

■ Lucy Partnership Terms Pending

Need to lock in 4mg/8mg availability, flavor access, and timeline. This is the gating factor for VIA and portfolio flexibility.

■ Premium Retail Pipeline in Early Stages

Exploratory conversations with Ulta/Sephora buyers, premium dispensary networks, and boutique partnerships are the medium-term play.

8. Open Decisions & Next Steps

Critical Path Decisions (Must resolve by March 2026 for Q2 launch):

1. Portfolio vs. Single Brand Launch

Do we launch NOON as a standalone brand first, or launch NOON + QUIET SOCIETY simultaneously as a portfolio play? Single brand is lower risk/faster; portfolio captures broader market but requires more capital.

2. Final Agency Scope & Budget

Lock TRIPTK's deliverables to visual execution only (site graphics, product shots, lifestyle photography, packaging renders) and confirm reduced budget.

3. Lucy Partnership Commercials

Finalize terms for 4mg/8mg access, flavor portfolio, and supply timeline. This is the gating item for VIA and the lower-strength entry point that addresses female product experience barriers.

4. DTC Platform & E-Commerce Build

Leverage Connor's e-commerce expertise to build DTC site. Key decisions: Shopify vs. custom, subscription mechanics, age verification integration.

5. Consumer Testing Design

Design protocol that tests concepts in realistic retail context. Budget and timeline for testing need to be scoped.

Medium-Term Workstreams (Q2–Q3 2026):

- Initiate premium retail buyer conversations (Ulta, Sephora, boutique networks)
- Develop the "Hardware Strategy" — design and source the QUIET SOCIETY compact/accessory for premium retail placement
- Build cannabis dispensary adjacency strategy (budtender seed program, co-marketing with female-led edible brands)
- Prepare TPB leadership presentation for additional 2026 Innovation funding
- Evaluate VIA subscription mechanics and supply chain feasibility for Phase 2 launch

9. Critical File Reference Guide

The following is a prioritized guide to all project files. Priority tiers indicate how critical each file is for **current decision-making and execution** (not historical importance).

TIER 1: MISSION-CRITICAL — Read These First

TRIPK_Concept_Evaluation_V2.docx

THE single most important document. Contains the final (V2) strategic assessment with the channel strategy reframe, updated scoring matrix, portfolio-tier architecture, and the "Big Bet" recommendation. This is the current strategic north star. V2 supersedes V1.

TRIPK x TPB Extended Brand Concepts compressed.pdf

The creative foundation. TRIPK's full concept deck with visual identity, brand narratives, RTBs, packaging concepts, and activation scenarios for all eight concepts (NOON, Quiet Society, Atlas, Just, Solstice, Stillpoint, Via, Dayturn). This is what you show stakeholders.

Channel_Strategy_Defense_TPB.docx

The strategic argument for leadership. The evidence-backed defense of the premium channel strategy over c-store distribution. Synthesizes McKinsey, BCG, and Bain research. Use this to defend the channel thesis in any internal pushback conversation.

TRIPK_Hypotheses_Framework.xlsx

The consumer truth backbone. Codified hypothesis framework (H5, H10, H11, H12, H18, etc.) that underpins all concept evaluation decisions. Every concept was scored against these hypotheses. This is the "why" behind the scoring.

Female_Nicotine_Pouch_US_Market_Sizing_9_8_25.xlsx

The business case. Independent market sizing model for the female nicotine pouch opportunity in the U.S. This is the quantitative foundation for the \$600M opportunity claim and is essential for any leadership funding presentation.

TIER 2: HIGH VALUE — Essential Context

TRIPK_Concept_Evaluation_v1.docx

First-round evaluation (superseded by V2 but useful for tracking how thinking evolved). V1 killed VIA on regulatory grounds and didn't include the channel lens. Comparing V1 to V2 shows how the Lucy partnership and channel reframe changed the strategic calculus.

FRE_Innovation_Steer_Co.docx

Internal steering committee briefing. Contains the "Hardware Strategy" loophole detail, cannabis dispensary adjacency strategy, and the premium channel playbook. Key document for understanding the broader innovation agenda and internal alignment.

v2_TPB_Female_Oral_Nicotine_Research_Campaign_1.pdf

The primary consumer research instrument. Full Vurvey research campaign questionnaire for both existing and non-existing oral nicotine users. Contains the exact probes on motivation, barriers, sensory preferences, gender/image perceptions, and brand design preferences that generated the hypothesis framework.

Turning_Point_Brands_TRIPTK_Female_Brand_Innovation_Brief_Draft_09_25.pdf

The original brief. Founding document that defined the strategic mandate, target audience hypothesis, partnership requirements, and anticipated agency services. Useful for tracking scope evolution.

Notes_FRE_Regulatory_Guardrails_OnePager.pdf

Regulatory constraints summary. One-page distillation of General Counsel guidance on what can and cannot be changed under existing PMTA approvals. The source for the MVP-Safe vs. Triggers-New-FDA-Path framework.

TIER 3: SUPPORTING — Reference as Needed**TRIPTK x TPB_NTW Female Oral Nicotine Brand Innovation Proposal V2.pdf**

TRIPTK's original proposal. The agency's pitch document outlining their five-phase process, team structure, AI-powered methodology, and deliverables. Useful for understanding what was scoped vs. what was delivered.

FRE_TRPTK_Executive_Summary.docx

High-level executive summary of the TRIPTK engagement. Condensed overview for senior leadership. Use if you need a quick brief for someone new to the project.

PMTA__PROJECT_FEMME.docx

PMTA regulatory analysis specific to Project Femme. Detailed regulatory pathway analysis for the female brand initiative.

FRE_Stakeholder_Interview_Probes.xlsx

Interview discussion guides. The probes/questions used during Phase 1 stakeholder interviews. Useful for replicating methodology or understanding what was asked.

TRIPTK_Interviewee_List_20251110.xlsx

Who was interviewed. List of internal and external interviewees for Phase 1 research.

Customer_Journey_map.xlsx

Consumer journey mapping. Maps the female consumer journey from awareness through purchase and retention. Informs touchpoint strategy.

LIFT_nootropics_pouch_forecast.xlsx

Adjacent concept forecast. Financial forecast for the LIFT nootropics pouch concept. Provides P&L modeling methodology that can be applied to Project Femme concepts.

FRE_Plus_Concepts_Organized.xlsx

FRE Plus concept portfolio. Organized catalog of FRE Plus concepts. Context for understanding the broader innovation pipeline.

10_FRE_COMMERCIAL_CONCEPTS.docx

FRE commercial concepts. Ten commercial concepts for FRE. Provides creative benchmarks and positioning language.

COTTON_MOUTH.docx

Cotton Mouth product background. Background on the Cotton Mouth (nicotine-infused cotton) product vehicle. Relevant if exploring Cotton Mouth as an alternative format for the female brand.

Potential_Beyond_Tobacco.docx

Broader beyond-tobacco strategy. TPB's strategic vision for portfolio expansion beyond traditional tobacco. Provides corporate strategic context.

FRE_Brand_Guidelines_A.pdf

FRE brand guidelines. Current FRE brand standards. Useful for understanding what the new brand must differentiate FROM.

TIER 4: VISUAL ASSETS

NOAT_Wintergreen_A1_660x660.webp / A2 / 10Pack

Product imagery assets (NOAT Wintergreen). Reference for visual benchmarking and competitive context.

This document represents the complete state of play for Project Femme as of February 2026. The strategic foundation is set. The consumer insights are validated. The concepts are scored and ranked. The channel thesis is defensible. The regulatory constraints are mapped. The product portfolio is defined. What remains is execution: lock the Lucy terms, build the DTC site, test concepts in context, and launch.

Prepared by the FRE Innovation Team | Turning Point Brands, Inc. | February 20, 2026